General Science

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About the Course

A primarily practical course, students explore the idea of biome, first their own and then others. They also 'meet' some less familiar creatures from their own, such as insect larva and mammals, through picture books. Coordinating afternoon activities are provided in Outdoor Work.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Science: Grade 2

About Science: Grade 2
In level 2, learners are developing familiarity and friendship with Creation through a broader scope of Things, more challenging text, and slightly more abstract concepts.

Science: Grade 2
The Big Picture:
To accomplish the goal of supporting a relationship with the Things of the Universe, a Mason science program consists of nature lore, natural history, and general science. Nature immersion, inquiry, community connection, and supportive literature are woven into each of these three parts. Form 1 learners in grades 1-3 are at the beginning of this relationship: developing familiarity and friendship with Creation. Their sense of community is primarily focused on their immediate environment at this stage, but they are curious about others. The familiarity with foundational knowledge grown and nurtured in Form 1 prepares them for greater curiosity and personal interest in Form 2.

Nature lore is timeless knowledge that is passed through a community, much like a grandmother passes on how to make that special bread when the dough just 'feels right.' Like Mason, we strive to pass on this knowledge primarily through outdoor work. Group nature walks, seasonal readings, and topics in scouting are provided as an Outdoor Work resource in the Quick Links. If desired, literature suggestions to support lore can be found in the Community Read Alouds resource (in Literature Grades 1-3).

Placement & Combining Tips

About Science: Grade 2
In level 2, learners are developing familiarity and friendship with Creation through a broader scope of Things, more challenging text, and slightly more abstract concepts.

Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
2	General Science: Grade 2 1 time/week 15 min	A Walk in the... Desert Giant Mama Built a Little Nest Monarch and Milkweed The Secret Life of the Skunk

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Science: Grade 2				
General Science: Grade 2		Natural History: Grade 2 Nature Walks &		

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Nature Notebook: Grade 2		Scouting: Grades 1-8		

Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Science: Grade 2
☐ Obtain any supplies indicated on the science or grade-level supply lists.
☐ Download any apps and shortcut any desired links.

Nature Lore:
☐ Bookmark your Outdoor Work Quick Link, so that you have it available on your weekly outing. Outdoor Work is generally flexible for your location and season and can be moved around in the schedule to incorporate or substitute Natural History Club outings.
☐ Print or bookmark grade-specific nature notebook suggestions to support natural history and general science. Notebooking can be done on a walk, during occupations, or as a field trip, as appropriate.

Special Topics & Field Trips

Science: Grade 2
☐ Learn a few of your local species on these special topics using the internet, field guides, or your local nature preserve, conservancy, or state/national park.
☐ Note whether there are particular locations nearby for the student to easily notice the special topics on walks or during afternoon occupations.

General Science: Grade 2
• Term 1: insects, especially ants and butterflies, flowers, trip to a natural history museum or butterfly house
• Term 2: birds and trees
• Term 3: animals, tree buds, trip to a pond and a creek, hopefully with wet/soft ground to observe animal tracks

Term Prep & Teacher Tips

Science: Grade 2
Object lesson prompts are woven into the lessons, as appropriate, but teachers are encouraged to read corresponding Handbook of Nature Study (HoNS) selections each term:

General Science: Grade 2
☐ Term 1: butterflies (Monarchs) p.305-310 and wildflowers, milkweed p.491-495 or aster p.506-509
☐ Term 2: trees p.618-626, bird nests p.46, and/or choose 1-2 local birds from p.50-143
☐ Term 3: skunks p.245-247 and/or choose one additional mammal in p.215-266

☐ Gather household items, typically easy for students to scavenge or teachers to obtain locally:
• any wildflower seeds or butterfly host plants (Term 1)
• pot/planter with soil or place in the ground to plant with a trowel
• optional: rock

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Reminders

General Science: Grade 2
☐ Raising caterpillars is planned for General Science in Term 1, so make a note in your calendar to order them at the appropriate time and be flexible with the schedule to accommodate their development and release according to the instruction that comes with them.

Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ View Book List Details

General Science: Grade 2

A Walk in the...

Desert Giant

Mama Built a Little Nest

Monarch and Milkweed

The Secret Life of the Skunk

Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ View Basic Supplies
∞ View Supply List Details

General Science: Grade 2

Butterfly Garden with Voucher to Obtain Larva

Household Items - General Science: Grade 2

Various Seashells

Quick Links

(No Quick Links Assigned)

Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.

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General Science: Grade 2

How To Teach

Introduce

• Begin each lesson with learners' existing knowledge. If the book or activity is new or unfamiliar, then look at the title, a picture, or guidance in the lesson plan to help discuss what students think, drawing on previous experience. If continuing or revisiting a topic or activity, then recap. The lesson plans often help with this.

• Some learners may benefit from using pictures or looking back briefly.

• Allow them time to share any concerns and come alongside, as needed.

Complete

• Read, or do, as instructed in the lessons, noting any Teacher Tips provided. Learners should always have their nature journal or some other notebook/paper available in case they need to draw or diagram during the lesson.

• When reading to pre-readers, point to the words as you read, even if it seems like they aren't paying attention.

• If learners do not understand a word or concept, do not worry. Try to show them with a picture or connect the idea to something they have seen in real life. They are learning much by the way and will likely build understanding over the term, the year, or beyond.

Narrate

• Process the ideas of the lesson by retelling the events in sequence, describing a scene or setting, explaining a concept, etc.

• Learners may use words, pictures, Legos, dolls, etc., to process and convey ideas in the manner most natural to them.

• Teachers may take turns to model.

Discuss

• Consider together any thoughts, confusion, or concerns about the passage.

• Questions/topics for further discussion are often provided in the lesson plans to help. There are no right or wrong answers to these. If teachers want to keep ideas active in the mind, these can also be used at other times to keep the ideas in the working memory.

Connect

• Follow any extra links, examine any sidebars in the text, look at pictures, etc., depending on learner interest.

• These can also be viewed as alternative ways to engage.

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General Science: Grade 2

Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.

Term 1

WEEK 1 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 1**

Looking for Ants Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Today, you will look for ants!

→ OBSERVE
Some good places to look are under small rocks, around logs, and in cracks. Use a stick to safely lift rocks. If you find ants, take some time to observe them. Use a magnifier if you have one. How many sections of the body can you see? From which do the legs come? Describe its antennae, jaws, and eyes. If you give it a drop of honey or a few crumbs, what does it do? If you find something else that you want to observe, you may take the time to do so. Spend about 10 minutes looking for ants.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Did you find ants? If so, describe their habitat. How does it provide food and shelter for them?

★ TEACHER TIP
If students seem anxious or unsure about their nature journal, teachers can encourage them by modeling, showing them many different examples, journaling in tandem, or serving as a scribe.

★ TEACHER TIP
If students find ants, this is a great opportunity for an object lesson. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can instead refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

★ TEACHER NOTE
If you haven't ordered your caterpillars yet, don't forget!

WEEK 2 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 2**

Insects and Plants

Materials: Monarch and Milkweed

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Look at the picture on the cover. What kinds of butterflies have you noticed before? What did they look like? Where were they?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
Monarch and Milkweed (whole book)

• The meadow where the flowers grow might be a good habitat for a butterfly, but they might also fly to other habitats to find flowers, as well. A 'biome' is all of the living things that live together in a community in neighboring habitats. Can you think of some different habitats in our biome, where we live, where butterflies might be able to find food and shelter?

★ TEACHER TIP
Let students enjoy the artwork in this picture book. If you need to take a break and finish it another time, that is fine.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 3 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 3**

Observing Caterpillars Activity

Materials: Nature Journal, caterpillars

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Let's take a close look at our caterpillars today.

★ TEACHER TIP
Raising butterflies provides many opportunities for object lessons on several stages of the insect's life over the next 2 weeks or so.

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Term 1

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes observing your caterpillars in their habitat today and plan to check on them every day to watch them change. What parts are you able to notice? What is the caterpillar doing?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you recall in what stage of the life cycle the caterpillar is?

WEEK 4

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 4

Observing Caterpillars or Pupae Activity

> Materials: Nature Journal, caterpillars/pupae

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Have you noticed if your caterpillars are changing? Take a close look today!

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes observing your caterpillars or pupae today, and plan to check on them every day to watch them change. What do you notice today?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

★ TEACHER TIP
The time that it takes for the butterflies to emerge will vary slightly, so enjoy them while you have them and release them based on the instructions that came with them.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 5

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 5

Observing Pupae or Butterflies? Activity

> Materials: Nature Journal, pupae/butterflies

→ INTRO
How have your caterpillars changed this week? Take a close look today.

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes observing your pupae or butterflies today, if you have not yet released them. What parts are you able to notice on the adult butterfly? What does the butterfly do when it emerges from the chrysalis? If you have released them already, then spend your time noticing wildflowers. What colors and shapes do you notice? Do ants, butterflies, or other insects visit them? If so, what do the insects look like? What are the insects doing?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell about what you recorded.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 6

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 6

Planting Host Plants Activity

> Materials: resource link, seeds/plants for local butterfly species, pot with soil or place in the garden, trowel, water

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ ACTIVITY

★ TEACHER TIP
To find out more about good host plants for your locale, ask your local nature preserve, conservancy, or state/national park, OR check out the resources at the link:

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Term 1

Plant one or more flowers for your local butterflies. You may plant seeds or seedlings, depending on what is most appropriate for your season and location.

∞ **Resource Link:** Xerces Society

WEEK 7

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 7

Wildflower Watching Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Let's notice the wildflowers that are growing this season! Do you suppose that butterflies visit your wildflowers?

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes noticing which wildflowers are growing this season. What colors and shapes do you notice? How many petals do they have? How are the petals arranged? Do ants, butterflies, or other insects visit them? If so, what do the insects look like? How many different types or sizes of insects? What are the insects doing?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you notice anyone already familiar to you? Do you notice anyone new?

★ TEACHER TIP
Today is a good opportunity for an object lesson on wildflowers. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can instead refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

WEEK 8

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 8

My Biome

Materials: A Walk in the [familiar biome]

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Look at the picture on the cover. Do you recognize any of the living things on the cover? All of these (and more) live together in a community in our biome, so let's read about that today.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
A Walk in the [familiar biome] (whole book)

• What different habitats did you recognize in the book?

★ TEACHER TIP
Let students enjoy the photographs in this picture book. If you need to take a break and finish it another time, that is fine.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 9

⬚ 15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 9

Observing a Community Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
Check on the wildflower that you planted for the butterflies.

→ OBSERVE
How has your wildflower grown or changed? Are there any insects or spiders visiting? Has it made seeds? Spend some time noticing who else lives in its habitat. What other plants are nearby? What birds do you see or hear?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

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Term 1

	Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed. • Tell about what you recorded.	
WEEK 10	**15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 10** *Noticing Insects Activity* Materials: Nature Journal PREP: Read Teacher Tip **→ INTRO** Notice a fly or other insect today. **→ OBSERVE** Look at the insect closely with your magnifier. Describe its antennae, jaws, and eyes. How many wings does it have? From which sections do the wings come? The legs? What else do you notice? **→ NARRATE & DISCUSS** Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed. • Tell about what you found or what you recorded.	★ TEACHER TIP Leave a small piece of meat outside in a safe location a few hours before the lesson. This can be a good opportunity for an object lesson with an insect, hopefully, a fly. **• NATURE NOTEBOOK** Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.
WEEK 11	**15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 11** *Revisiting Your Host Plant Activity* Materials: Nature Journal PREP: Read Teacher Tip **→ INTRO** Spend about 10 minutes with your plant from earlier in the term. **→ OBSERVE** How has your plant grown or changed? Are there any animals visiting your plant yet? Does it have flowers? Has it made seeds? Describe any leaves or stalks. **→ NARRATE & DISCUSS** Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed. • Tell about what you found or what you recorded.	★ TEACHER TIP If a student's particular plant will not sprout until next spring, then they might observe birds today instead. **• NATURE NOTEBOOK** Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.
WEEK 12	**15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 12** *Exam Week* **→ EXAMS** Answer question(s) related to the course. Questions will come from: Nature Journal, Monarch and Milkweed, A Walk in the	**• NATURE NOTEBOOK** Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

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General Science: Grade 2

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Term 2

WEEK 1 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 13**

Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Let's spend some time to get to know a particular tree. This will be your tree, so pick one that you can revisit often.

→ OBSERVE
Choose a special tree near your home or school (i.e., one that you can visit regularly). Spend about 10 minutes getting to know your tree. You can even give it a special name. Does it have leaves on it right now, or have the leaves fallen? Look at them closely, so that you can see them with your eyes closed. What color are the leaves? Is their shape oval, heart-shaped, star-shaped, or something else? Are the edges smooth or jagged/ridged? With your eyes closed, touch the bark with your fingertips. What do you notice? Do you think you could tell this tree's bark from another without looking? If not, touch it again to get to know it better.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell about your tree.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

★ TEACHER TIP
If students notice trees during their outdoor time, this could be a good opportunity for an object lesson. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can instead refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

WEEK 2 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 14**

Meeting a Keystone Species

Materials: Desert Giant

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Last term, you noticed that creatures in a community sometimes depend on each other, like butterflies and flowers. Have you ever noticed creatures other than butterflies and flowers that depend on each other? Look at the picture on the cover. This tree is a habitat for the birds, but so many other creatures depend on it, as well. So many creatures in its habitat depend on it that it is a "keystone species." Let's read and find out about that.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
Desert Giant (whole book)

• Based on the story, what do you think is meant by "keystone species"? What creatures in your biome (or other creatures, if you are in the desert biome) seem to hold the whole community together?

→ SUPPLEMENTAL
∞ Image Link: Wikipedia: Keystone

★ TEACHER TIP
Some students will grasp the 'big picture' that a keystone holds the larger structure together, but others might need help or might get stuck on the word itself. Use the link or draw a diagram, if needed.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

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General Science: Grade 2

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Term 2

WEEK 3

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 15

Observing a Seashell Activity

Materials: Nature Journal, seashells, optional: a rock

→ INTRO
In the marine/saltwater biome, oysters are a keystone species. Oysters eat algae, balance nutrient levels in the water, provide food, and build habitats for other creatures. Like oysters, many ocean creatures live inside shells that give them a unique way of life. It is amazing to think that the shells we find at the beach are the homes of other creatures! Let's notice some of these beautiful creature homes today!

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes today noticing the beauty and uniqueness of one or more seashells. What colors and patterns do you notice? What is the texture? Where do you suppose the animal resides?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell about what you recorded. Compare a seashell with a rock. How are they similar or different?

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 4

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 16

Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Visit your tree again to learn something new about your friend.

→ OBSERVE
Notice any twigs and/or fruit that you can collect. Study the twigs and/or fruit for about 10 minutes. What color is the twig? How does the bark compare to that of the tree? Is it straight or are there any bumps or shoots? If so, how are those bumps/shoots arranged?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell what you learned about your tree.

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on twigs.

WEEK 5

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 17

Bird Watching Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Have you noticed which birds are visiting this week?

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes bird watching. What colors, markings, and shapes do you notice? Do they visit particular plants or trees? What is the bird

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on birds.

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doing? What is its posture (i.e., how does it hold its body)?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you notice anyone already familiar to you? Do you notice anyone new?

WEEK 6 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 18**

Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Sometimes we notice more when we compare. Let's try this today to notice even more about our tree.

→ OBSERVE
Collect twigs from your tree and a different tree, and spend about 10 minutes studying them. What color is the twig? How does the bark compare to that of the tree? Is it straight or are there any bumps or shoots? If so, how are those bumps/shoots arranged?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell what you learned about your tree.

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on twigs. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

WEEK 7 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 19**

Birds and Their Nests

Materials: Mama Built a Little Nest

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Have you ever found a bird nest? What was it made of? How was it made? Where was it? What trees or other plants were nearby? These are all clues to who built it because each bird lives differently within its community.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
Mama Built a Little Nest (whole book)

• Do you think anyone has had a nest in your tree? Why or why not?

★ TEACHER TIP
Let students enjoy the artwork in this picture book. If you need to take a break and finish it another time, that is fine.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 8 **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 20**

Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
Changing our perspective (our view) can also help us notice more. Let's change our perspective and see what else we can notice about our tree.

→ OBSERVE
Observe your tree from a distance and up close. How is your tree shaped? What is the land like around it? Do other plants or animals live near your tree? How do you think they help your tree? How do you suppose your tree

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helps them?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell what you learned about your tree.

WEEK 9

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 21
Nest Investigation Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Spend about 10 minutes today looking for or studying a bird nest. If you don't find one, that's still a good observation! Note where you looked and what you did see during your search.

→ OBSERVE
Since the songbirds are not nesting in the winter, any nests you find should be old and not in use, but observe them in place anyway. Another creature may reuse the nest or its material in the future. Discover as many clues as you can as to who built the nest. What was it made of? How was it made? Where was it? What trees or other plants were nearby?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• If you found a nest, do you have an idea about who built it? You can ask a local naturalist or park ranger to confirm your guess - they love to help!

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a bird's nest.

WEEK 10

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 22
Nest Investigation Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Spend about 10 minutes today looking for or studying a bird nest. If you didn't find one last week, look in a different location or in different places today. You are a nature detective!

→ OBSERVE
Since the songbirds are not nesting in the winter, any nests you find should be old and not in use, but observe them in place anyway. Another creature may reuse the nest or its material in the future. Discover as many clues as you can as to who built the nest. What was it made of? How was it made? Where was it? What trees or other plants were nearby?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• If you found a nest, do you have an idea about who built it? You can ask a local naturalist or park ranger to confirm your guess - they love to help!

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a bird's nest.

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Term 2

WEEK 11	**15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 23** *Bird Watching Activity* Materials: Nature Journal PREP: Read Teacher Tip **→ INTRO** Which birds are visiting this week? Let's take notice! **→ OBSERVE** Spend about 10 minutes bird watching. What colors, markings, and shapes do you notice? Do they visit particular plants or trees? What is the bird doing? What is its posture (i.e., how does it hold its body)? **→ NARRATE & DISCUSS** Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed. • Do you notice anyone already familiar to you? Do you notice anyone new?	★ TEACHER TIP This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a bird.
WEEK 12	**15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 24** *Exam Week* **→ EXAMS** Answer question(s) related to the course. Questions will come from: Nature Journal, Mama Built a Little Nest, Desert Giant	

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Term 3

WEEK 1

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 25

Meeting a Unique Mammal

Materials: The Secret Life of the Skunk

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Look at the picture on the cover. Have you ever seen a skunk? What would you do if you came across one on a walk? We don't often get to learn about skunks or any of the wild mammals in our biome up close, so let's read to find out more.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
The Secret Life of the Skunk (whole book)

• Have you ever smelled a skunk before? Take note of any skunky smell this term. When and where does it occur? How long does it last? Foxes smell very similar to skunks during mating season, but their season is a little earlier than skunks, and their odor doesn't tend to 'stick' quite as long.

★ TEACHER TIP
Let students enjoy the artwork in this picture book. If you need to take a break and finish it another time, that is fine.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 2

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 26

Mammal Investigation Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Wild mammals usually hide from humans, but we can learn about them by following their tracks. Spots with soft or wet soil are good for footprints, but if your soil is very dry, then you might still be able to find other signs, like scat or leftover food.

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes today looking for or studying animal tracks (or other sign). What is the size and shape? Are there claws visible? How many toes? Is there more than one animal? Are they the same or different? Which way are they pointing? How would you describe this habitat? What other plants and animals live in this biome?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you know who made any tracks or left any sign that you found? If not, what other clues might help? If so, you can ask a local naturalist or park ranger to confirm your guess - they love to help!

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on animal signs. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can instead refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

WEEK 3

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 27

Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Revisit your tree today to see what has changed.

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a twig.

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Term 3

→ OBSERVE
Closely examine its twigs and look carefully at the buds. What color is the twig? What color and shape are the buds? Study the form of the buds. Can you guess what the layers of the bud will look like when they open? How are those buds arranged? Bring a small twig inside to place in some water. Watch the buds throughout the day to observe any changes.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell what you learned about your tree.

WEEK 4

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 28

Bird Watching Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Today is a good day to notice which birds are visiting.

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes bird watching. What colors, markings, and shapes do you notice? Do they visit particular plants or trees? Do they visit particular plants or trees? If so, study the tree to see if you can find reasons for this. What is the bird doing?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you notice anyone already familiar to you? Do you notice anyone new?

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a bird.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 5

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 29

Looking for Beetles Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Today, you will look for beetles, an insect that has a pair of hardened wings covering their flight wings.

→ OBSERVE
Some good places to look are under small rocks, on plants, and in grass and leaf litter. Use a stick to safely lift rocks. If you find beetles, take some time to observe them. Use a magnifier if you have one. What parts of the body do you see? What colors are its hard shell? Describe its antennae, jaws, and eyes. If you give it a gentle nudge with a blade of grass or leaf, does it take off and let you see its wings? If you find someone else that you want to observe, you may take the time to do so. Spend about 10 minutes looking for beetles.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Did you find beetles? If so, describe their habitat. How does it provide food and shelter for them?

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on a beetle or other insect. Questions are embedded in the lesson to help, as needed. If preferred, teachers can refer to the Handbook of Nature Study or allow questions to flow naturally between student and teacher.

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→ SUPPLEMENTAL
∞ Video Link: Ladybug Wings (1:26)

WEEK 6 ⬚ **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 30**
Looking for Beetles Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
Today, you will look for beetles again. If you find beetles, take some time to observe them. Use a magnifier if you have one. If not, then observe whatever nature provides.

→ OBSERVE
If you find a beetle, notice what parts of the body you see. What colors are its hard shell? Describe its antennae, jaws, and eyes. If you give it a gentle nudge with a blade of grass or leaf, does it take off and let you see its wings? If you find someone else that you want to observe, you may take the time to do so. Spend about 10 minutes looking for beetles.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Did you find beetles? If so, describe their habitat. How does it provide food and shelter for them?

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 7 ⬚ **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 31**
Your Biome

Materials: A Walk in the [different biome]

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Look at the picture on the cover. Do you recognize any of the living things on the cover? This book is about a living community or biome that is different from ours, so let's read and find out the ways that it is similar, but unique.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS
A Walk in the [different biome] (whole book)

• Did you recognize habitats in this book that are similar to some where you live? What plants and animals were the same or similar and which were different? Were there habitats or creatures (e.g. insects, birds, mammals, trees, etc) in them that were very different from anything where you live?

★ TEACHER TIP
Let students enjoy the photographs in this picture book. If you need to take a break and finish it another time, that is fine.

WEEK 8 ⬚ **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 32**
Comparing Tracks Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
What kinds of tracks have you noticed? Let's compare different tracks today and think about what stands out.

→ OBSERVE
Spend about 10 minutes studying and copying the tracks at the link (or some of them). Which ones stand out as being unique? Which ones might be easily

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

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confused? What features are distinctive about each one?
∞ Image Link: Track and Sign

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Have you seen any of these tracks before?

WEEK 9

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 33
Mammal Investigation Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO
Spend some time studying and comparing any tracks that you have recorded so far, or look for more in the soft earth.

→ OBSERVE
Do any of your tracks have the distinctive features you noticed last week? What is the size and shape? Are there claws visible? How many toes? What is the land like near the animal sign? Are there other signs of animal activity?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Do you know who made the tracks or left the signs that you found? If so, you can ask a local naturalist or park ranger to confirm your guess - they love to help!

★ TEACHER TIP
This could be a good opportunity for an object lesson on animal signs.

WEEK 10

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 34
Knowing a Tree Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
Revisit your tree again this week.

→ OBSERVE
Closely examine your tree's twigs and look carefully at the buds if they remain. If they have already opened, look carefully at the new flowers and/or leaves. What is their color and texture? How many are grouped together? What is their shape? Do all of the flowers on your tree look the same, or are there different kinds of flowers on the same tree?

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS
Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed.

• Tell what you learned about your tree.

• NATURE NOTEBOOK
Prompt for General Science in Outdoor Work Quick Link.

WEEK 11

15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 35
Noticing Insects Activity

Materials: Nature Journal

→ INTRO
Notice flying insects today.

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Term 3

	➜ OBSERVE Are the bees active? Have you seen butterflies or beetles flying? Are you close enough to the water to see dragonflies, damselflies, or lacewings? What do you notice these insects doing? Where are they? Can you observe closely enough to examine their wings? Compare how different insects fly. How do they use their wings differently? **➜ NARRATE & DISCUSS** Use a nature journal to record what the student(s) noticed. • Tell about what you found or what you recorded.	
WEEK 12	⬚ **15m General Science: Grade 2 - Lesson 36** *Exam Week* **➜ EXAMS** Answer question(s) related to the course. Questions will come from: Nature Journal, A Walk in the ...., The Secret Life of the Skunk	

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General Science: Grade 2

Examination

Term 1

· Tell about or draw 3 different habitats in your biome in which a butterfly lives.

Term 2

· Tell about or draw a tree in your biome with at least 3 ways that others depend upon it.

Term 3

· Tell about or draw a creature from your biome and compare it to a creature from another biome.

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